drug. It may appear harmless to the smoker. But I, as manager of their health, cannot be deceived by that. As drugs have a bad effect, so does smoking tobacco. Innumerable bronchial and lung problems are caused by it. If you're handling your own life and paying for its upkeep, it's okay with me. But when it is my responsibility to keep the prisoner healthy, when it is my responsibility to pay for his physical upkeep, and to pay from resources that as it is fall short of the more beneficial targets at higher priorities, then I have to make my own choices. Just look at the overcrowding in the jails. Where there is space meant for 20 prisoners we have 80. You can imagine what the incidence of passive smoking must be. Till I left we were treating several prisoners for bronchial problems, and for TB. Where does the money come from for their medical treatment? From the prison budget. So, whether you like us for it or not, we just do not have the funds or the inclination to push your habit.

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* The Anand Narain Mulla Committee was set up in the early 1980s to suggest prison reforms.